

PROGRAM OVERVIEW • 2025

# GreenRoots Youth Corps

A paid pathway from the Cedar River banks to a green-collar career, for youth the labor market left behind.



# We pay young people to restore the Cedar River — and train them into green jobs.

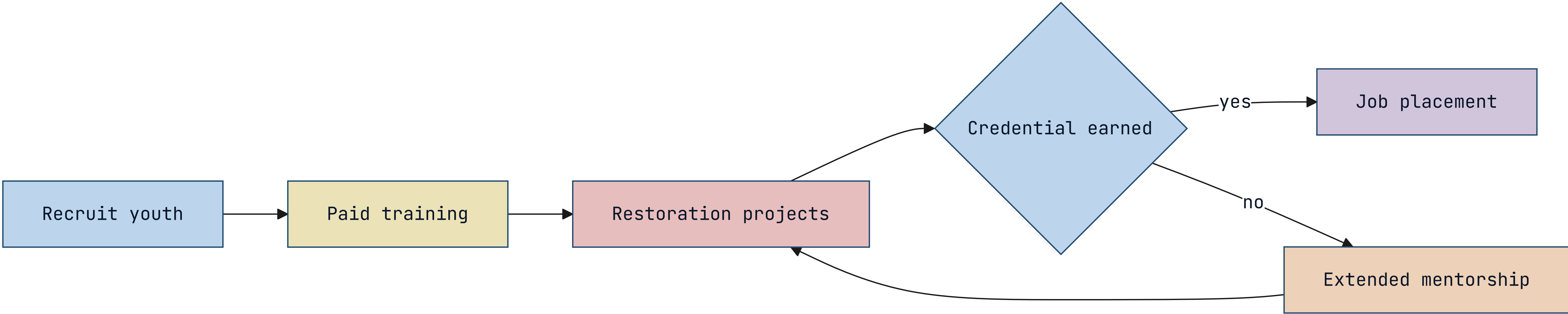
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GreenRoots is a 16-week paid program for youth ages 16–24 in Cedar Rapids' East River neighborhoods. Crews restore habitat across the watershed while earning a wage, certifications, and a direct line to hiring partners.

- Participants earn \$16/hour from their first day in the field.
- The work is real: erosion control, native planting, trail repair under contract.



# Our theory of change, from intake to a green career.





# A participant's path through the program.

STEP 01

**Recruit**

Outreach through high schools and reentry partners brings youth into a paid four-week orientation.

STEP 02

**Train**

Twelve weeks of field training in habitat restoration, chainsaw and first-aid certs, and job-readiness coaching.

STEP 03

**Work**

Crews complete real restoration contracts across the Cedar River watershed, earning a wage and a portfolio.

STEP 04

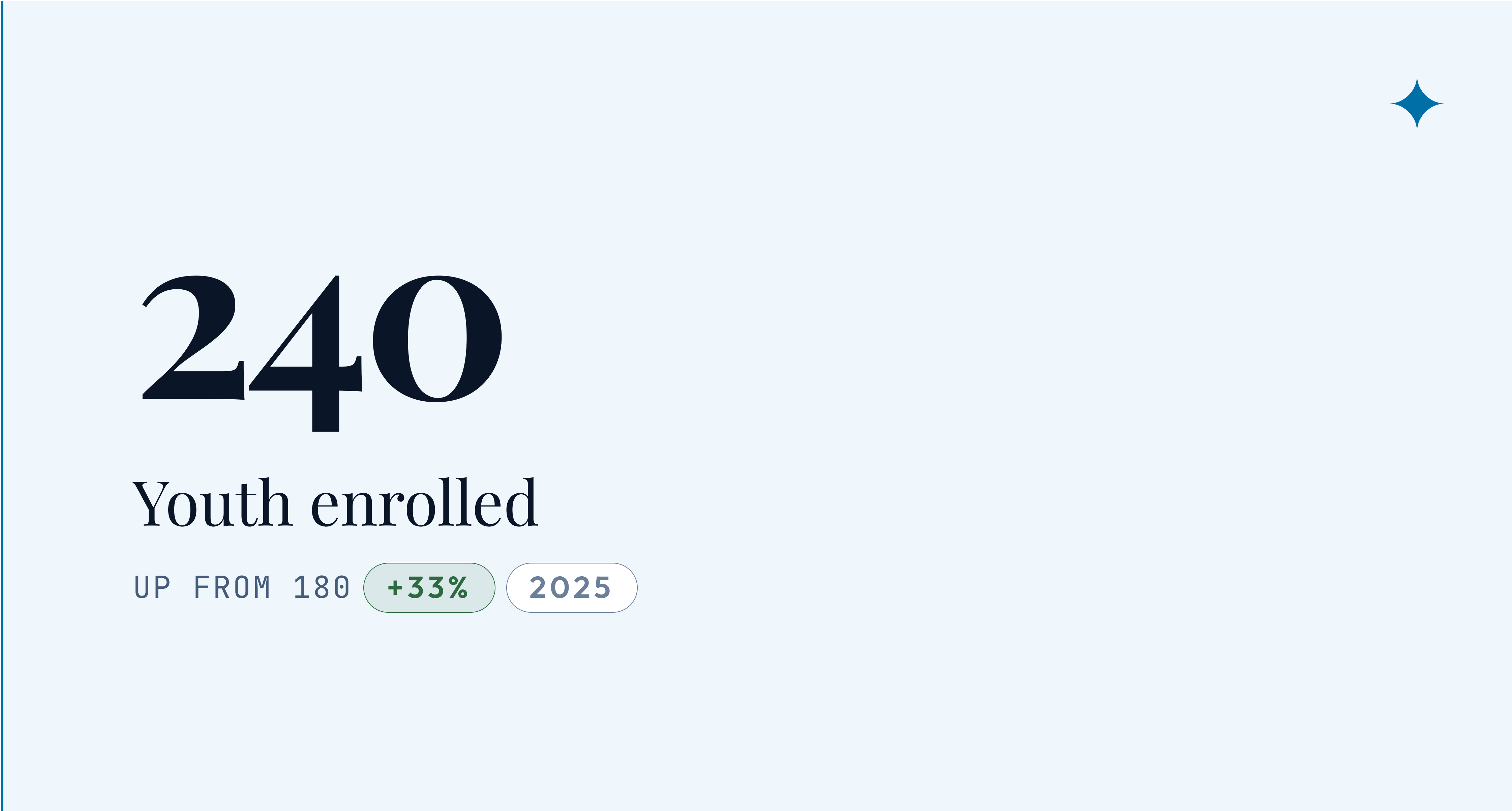
**Place**

Case managers match graduates to employer partners or post-secondary programs and check in for a year.



OUTCOMES • 2025

# More youth enrolled, and more left with a job or a school seat.



78%

Placed or in school

TARGET 70% **ON PLAN** VERIFIED

91%

Credential earned

OF THOSE WHO FINISHED **ON PLAN**  
AUDITED



# Who we serve, and who delivers the program.

## Youth participants

Ages 16–24

240 young people from the East River neighborhoods, paid \$16/hr while they train.

## Program staff

GreenRoots team

Eight crew leaders and two case managers run daily restoration work and aftercare.

## Employer partners

14 partners

Parks departments, utilities, and landscaping firms that hire our graduates directly.



“

*I'd been kicked out of two schools before this. Out here I learned I could lead a crew. Now I run a parks team and I'm back in night classes.*

”

— Devon Reyes, 2025 graduate, GreenRoots Youth Corps



THE EARNINGS STORY BEHIND A PLACEMENT

**\$18,600**

average annual earnings for a placed  
graduate one year out — first steady  
income for most.



IMPACT • 2025

# A single season of restoration, by the numbers.





# Recruitment reaches the young people other programs miss.

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We draw enrollees from Cedar Rapids' three highest-unemployment neighborhoods. Two reentry organizations, the public library, and four high schools drive most qualified referrals into the program.

- 61% of the 240 enrollees came from those priority neighborhoods.
- 44% had a prior justice-system contact; 29% were not enrolled in school at intake.



# The work itself is the curriculum.

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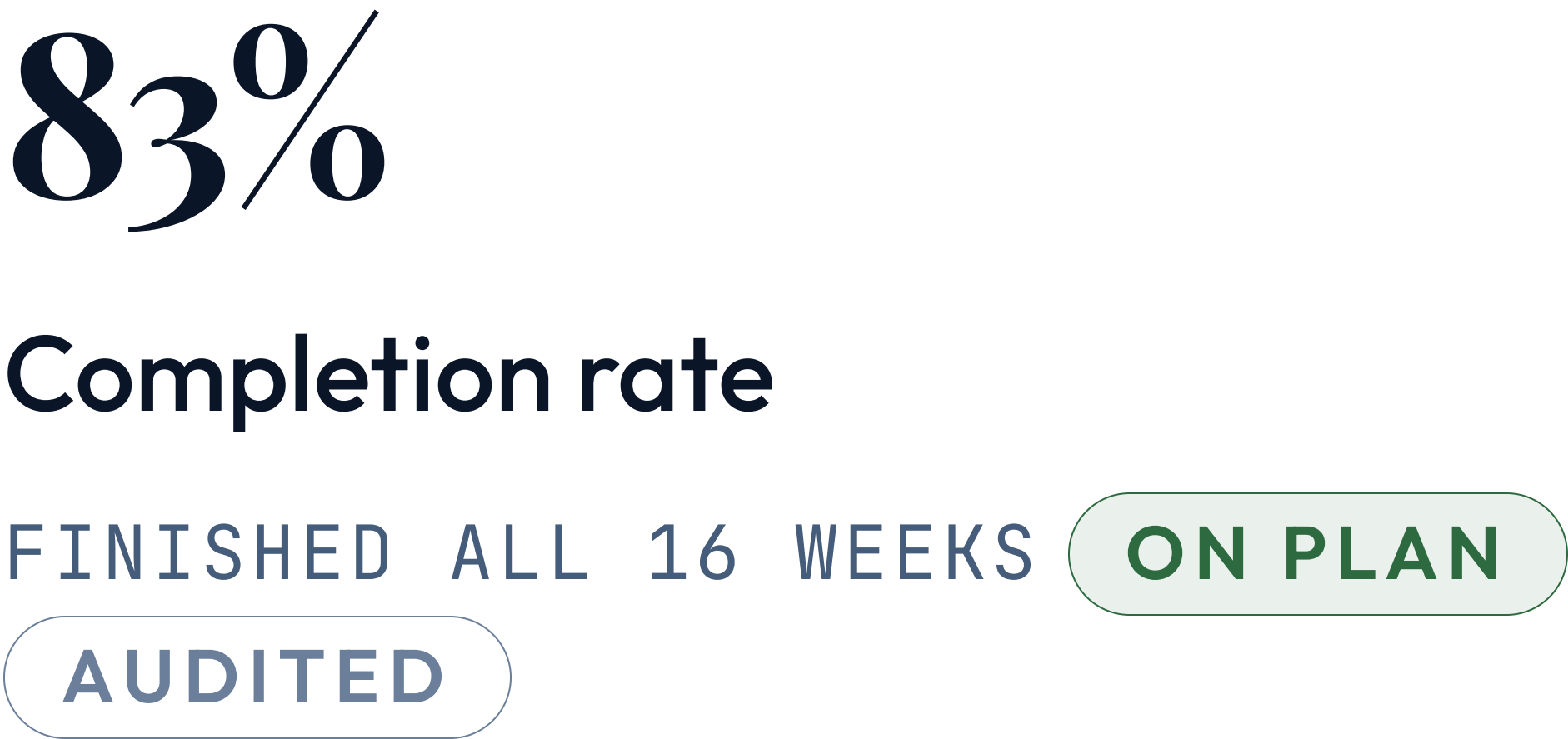
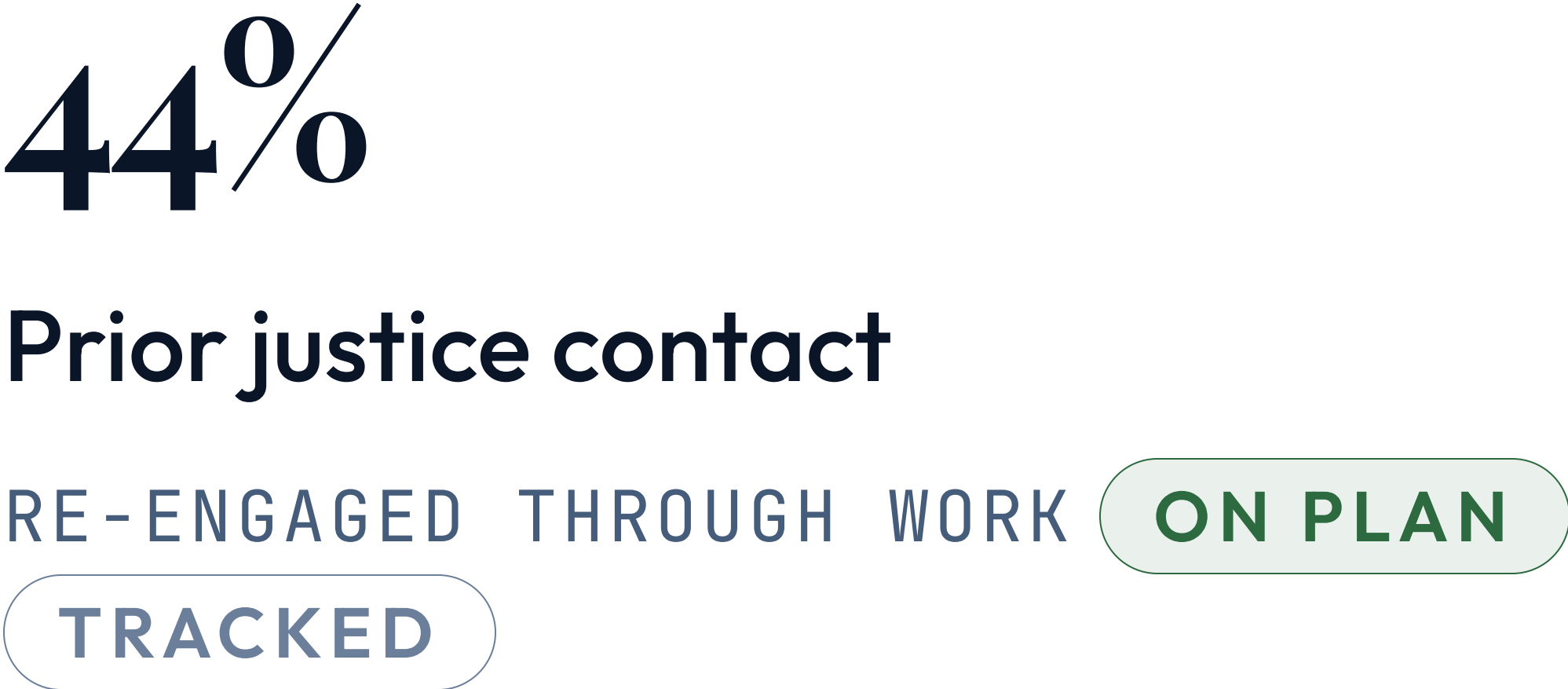
Crews spend their days on contracted restoration — removing invasive honeysuckle, planting native buffers, and stabilizing eroded banks along the Cedar River. The wage and the certifications come from doing real work, not simulations.

- Field days are paired with two afternoons a week of certs and job-readiness coaching.
- Every graduate leaves with a portfolio of completed restoration sites.



EQUITY • 2025

# The program reaches and keeps the youth it sets out to serve.





COST • 2025

# Public dollars stretch further than a year of incarceration.

*All figures from audited spend over 240 enrollees and 187 placements.*





# Two things ran harder than planned this year.

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A spring flood closed three worksites for five weeks, compressing the field calendar. Our fall cohort enrolled 52 against a 70-seat plan after a bus-route cut stranded referrals.

- We recovered field hours by extending contracts into the dry early-winter weeks.
- A transit stipend restored the next cohort to full size.



THE PLAN • 2026-2028

# Where the next three seasons take the Corps.

| WORKSTREAM      | NOW     | BUILD         | SCALE            |
|-----------------|---------|---------------|------------------|
|                 | 2025    | 2026          | 2027             |
| Youth served    | ✓ 240   | ✖ 320         | ○ 450            |
| Hiring partners | ✓ 14    | ✖ 22          | ○ 30             |
| Watersheds      | ✓ Cedar | ✖ +Iowa River | ○ +Wapsipinicon  |
| Certifications  | ✓ 3     | ✖ +Arborist   | ○ +Water quality |

✓ Shipped

✖ In flight

○ Planned



# **We are ready to grow — and we are asking partners to grow with us.**

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The model holds: 240 youth served, 78% placed or in school, 84 cents of every dollar reaching participants. We are inviting funders and employers to help extend the Corps to a second watershed in 2026.

- A second site would add 80 paid seats and eight new hiring partners.
- Every expansion dollar is matched by contracted restoration revenue.



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Pay a young person to heal a  
river, and you get back both  
a watershed and a worker.